

CITY UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG, DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC AND INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS SEM A, A.Y. 2026/27

COMPARATIVE POLITICS AND SOCIETIES

PIA2050 | WEEK 4: A WORLD OF 'NATION-STATES'

LAST WEEK/THIS WEEK

Our last class was dedicated to the formulation of a kind of mechanism by which we may be able to make sense of the progression of history.

We said that political development is largely about the competition between groups—competition may revolve around material resources, or alternative visions of how a society should be organized/governed, or around competing claim for "inter-subjective recognition."

Having covered how to study political development, this week we start to focus on what political development is actually about—one of the most important aspects of comparative political development over the past several centuries has been the world's transformation into a world of "nation-states."

Today's class is dedicated to the processes responsible for this outcome: processes of state-formation and nation-building.

THE MODERN STATE

By far the dominant form of political organization today is generally referred to as "the modern state." According to Max Weber (1919), "The state is an organization that successfully claims a monopoly on the legitimate use of physical force within a given territory." Note the key concepts here:

(i) An organization: Entails a set of formalized administrative, bureaucratic, legal, coercive agencies operating through the continuous, regulated activities of individuals acting as occupants of offices.

(ii) Monopoly of legitimate physical force: Excludes the possibility of more than one organization exercising legitimate physical force.

(iii) A well-defined territory: Assumes you can draw a line determining how far a state's "sovereignty" extends (and where it ends).

SOVEREIGNTY

What is "sovereignty?" We distinguish between:

(1) External sovereignty: When we say that a certain country is "sovereign," we mean that the country is independent and self-governing. Violations of "external sovereignty" are acts that prevent/impede a country's right to govern itself.

(2) Internal sovereignty: Speaks to who the "sovereign" is—meaning, where does power ultimately reside? In Medieval kingdoms, the king was the sovereign (was understood to own all land/life in the kingdom). Today most countries claim that "the people" or "the nation" are/is sovereign. In practice, German philosopher Carl Schmit (1888-1985) provided a useful criterion to figure out who really is sovereign:

"Sovereign is he who decides on the exception."

*W*here a "state of exception" is defined as a severe disturbance requiring the application of extraordinary measures.

STATE MAKING

With some exceptions, the characteristics of "modern states" are fairly recent innovations—the world wasn't always governed this way. In turn, this consideration raises two key questions:

(1) How did we end up with modern states?
In other words, how did modern states develop?
How did the modern state prevail over other forms of political organization?

(2) Why did we end up with the states we have today?
In other words, why were some specific attempts at state-making or state-formation successful, while many others were not?
And what accounts for the location of the boundaries within which the existing states exercise their sovereignty?

STATE MAKING

The countries that saw the earliest successful efforts to develop the characteristics of modern states are located in East Asia, esp. China.

China was unified under a single empire during the Qin Dynasty in 221 BCE; there, the adoption of a hierarchical, merit-based bureaucracy with high degree of central control over "peripheries" precedes the same development in the West by many centuries.

Confucian ideas drove the creation of a bureaucracy based on merit, not hereditary aristocracy: examinations to select the most competent administrators for the country's bureaucracy have been in use (intermittently) since the year 605CE.

By the year 1400 CE, China, Korea, Japan, and Vietnam had developed centralized, strong states with hierarchically structured bureaucracies extending to much of their territory (which was not demarcated very precisely; indeed, precise demarcation of territory was not considered a priority at the time).

STATE MAKING

In Europe, the process of state formation took many (more) centuries. The process originates in ancient Greece and, especially, Rome.

By the year 100 CE, the Roman Empire had managed to establish a centralized system of government and administration; territorial expansion went hand-in-hand with innovations in roads and infrastructure. The Empire went through centuries of decline, then broke up in the year 476 CE.

The decline and eventual dissolution of the Roman Empire gave rise to a situation characterized by political fragmentation, which was reinforced by economic decay, the collapse of trade/commerce and productivity, the ruin of Roman infrastructure (roads, bridges, aqueducts), and decreasing levels of literacy and life expectancy.

These were the so-called "Dark Ages," the darkest of which were comprised roughly between 500-800CE. The "Middle Ages" are roughly comprised between 500-1500.


The Roman Empire
in 117 AD, at its greatest extent
Britannia
Belgica
Germania Superior
Lugdunensis
Oceanus Atlanticus
Noricum
Aquitania
Raetia
Pannonia
Dacia
Narbonensis
Dalmatia
Moesia
Pontus Euxinus
Italia
Tarraconensis
Corsica
Roma
Thracia
Macedonia
Lusitania
Sardinia
Epirus
Bithynia et Pontus
Armenia
Asia
Galatia
Cappadocia
Baetica
Sicilia
Lycia
Cilicia
Achaia
Africa
Assyria
Mauretania
Mare Internum
Syria
Cyprus
Mesopotamia
Iudaea
Cyrenaica
Arabia Petraea
Aegyptus



The “Dark Ages” (500-800CE)

STATE MAKING

At this time, the dominant form of political-economic organization was "Feudalism," characterized by weak central governments ("feudal anarchy").

Emperors and kings were theoretically in charge of large territories, but did not really control much territory beyond their capitals. The rights to land and peoples were given to local rulers, who in turn divided it up between other, smaller lords. Inferior lords payed tribute, supplied manpower for war; got protection in return.

Originally, "fiefs" were not hereditary (delegated by the Emperor or a superior lord), but gradually local lords and their families took over, leading to a proliferation of autonomous units often at war with each other.

Economically, the system was characterized by the fact that peasants (as serfs) were legally tied to the land they cultivated, thereby forming part of the lord's property.

STATE MAKING

Note that each of the features of a modern state was missing:

(i) No real state "organization," but a system of government based on personal ties of mutual obligation; officials were understood to "own" the offices they occupied.

(ii) No definite territory—territories were ill-defined and the degree of authority exercised by a "King" or "Emperor" varied a great deal depending on a given territory's distance from the nominal "capital."

(iii) No "monopoly of legitimate force:" local lords were in practice often allegiant to multiple superiors, whose real authority was weak and often overlapping—multiple noblemen may have had claims to a local lord's provision of tribute and conscription.

Of note during this time were some early attempts to centralize power—the most successful ones in Western and Northern Europe, the least successful ones in Central Europe.

STATE MAKING

In Central Europe, efforts made to consolidate a "Holy Roman Empire" (beginning in 800 CE) ended up failing. For a variety of reasons—incl. the Catholic Church's attempts to undermine the Emperor's authority—fragmentation remained the rule in territories corresponding to modern Germany and Italy until the mid-1800s.

Despite the fragmentation, this region would eventually see the emergence of powerful/prosperous cities and city-states, which led to the rediscovery of humanistic ideas and classical writings ("the Renaissance," circa 1400-1600 CE), the deterioration in the Church's power, as well as the resumption of economic growth, technological progress, and the "age of discovery."

Conversely, Western and Northern Europe witnessed the rise of relatively centralized kingdoms in Portugal, Spain, France, England, Scotland, Denmark, Sweden, etc.; by 1400 CE, these kingdoms already had similar sizes and boundaries as they do today.



814

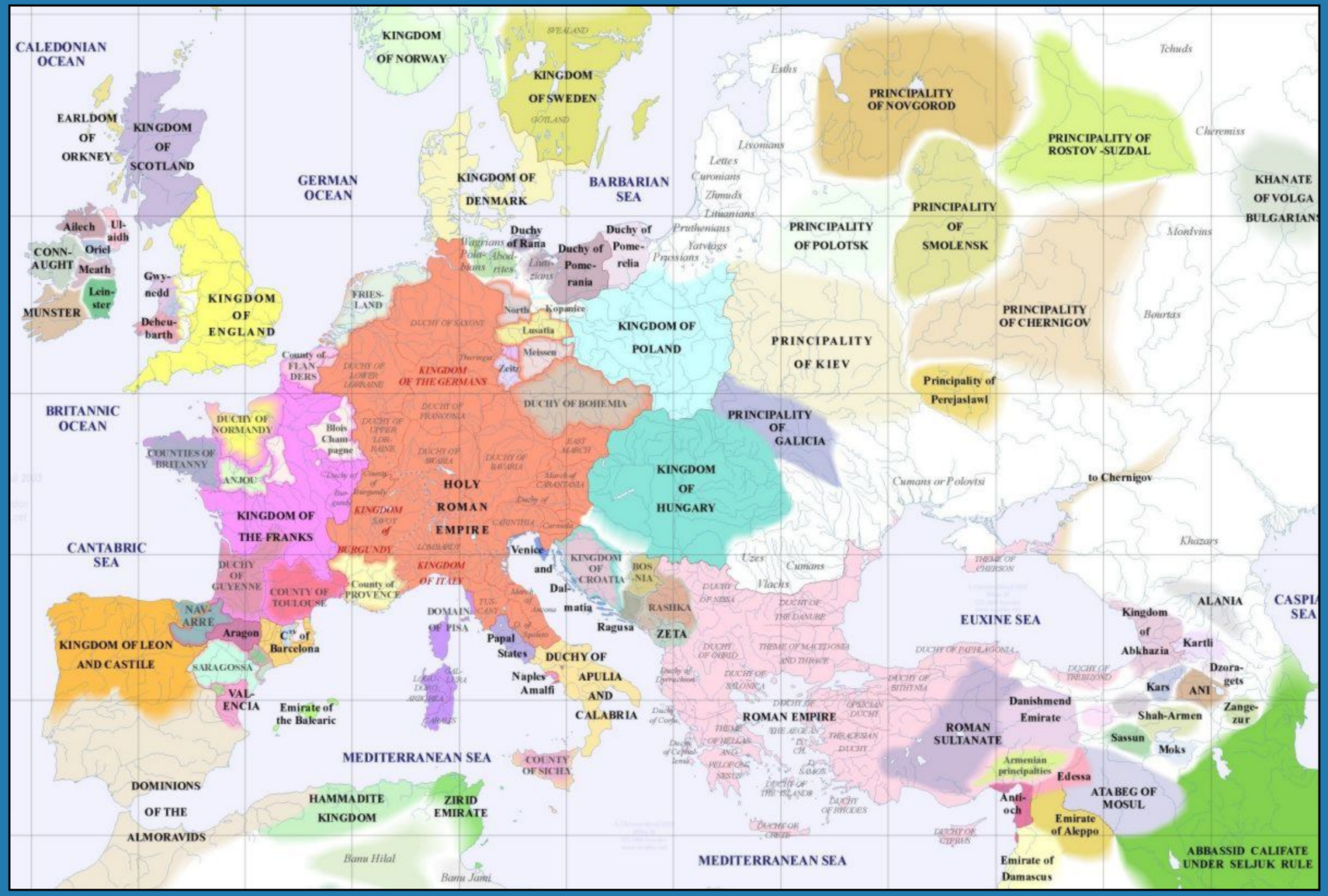


843



1250

The “Holy Roman Empire”



Europe in 1100 CE



Europe in 1400 CE

STATE MAKING

The period between 1400-1600 CE was decisive for state-building in Europe. The impulse was provided by the region's constant state of war, which required ever-increasing amounts of money as well as increasingly large, permanent, and well-equipped armed forces. As historian/sociologist Charles Tilly (1975: 42) put it:

"War made the state, and the state made war."

Organizations capable of governing an entire country effectively and more or less uniformly throughout the national territory became crucial for their rulers to extract the resources and mobilize the manpower required to fight wars.

Innovations introduced for that purpose included standing armies, bureaucracies to administer/tax populations more effectively, systems of judicial courts to adjudicate disputes and facilitate trade.

STATE MAKING

The key innovation made in Europe between 1500-1800 is the system of "royal absolutism." Under this system, the ruler had (at least theoretically) "absolute" power. The King of France, Louis XIV, said it best: "L' tat, c'est moi."

Attempts to centralize power were met with multiple sources of resistance, which were subdued brutally. As Tilly (1985: 17-19) has written:

> The state-makers only imposed their wills on the populace through centuries of ruthless effort. The effort took many forms: creating distinct staffs dependent on the crown and loyal to it; making those staffs (armies and bureaucrats alike) reliable, effective instruments of policy; blending coercion, co-optation and legitimation as means of guaranteeing the acquiescence of different segments of the population; acquiring sound information about the country, its people and its resources; promoting economic activities which would free and create resources for the use of the state. ... Thus it became a game of shifting coalitions.

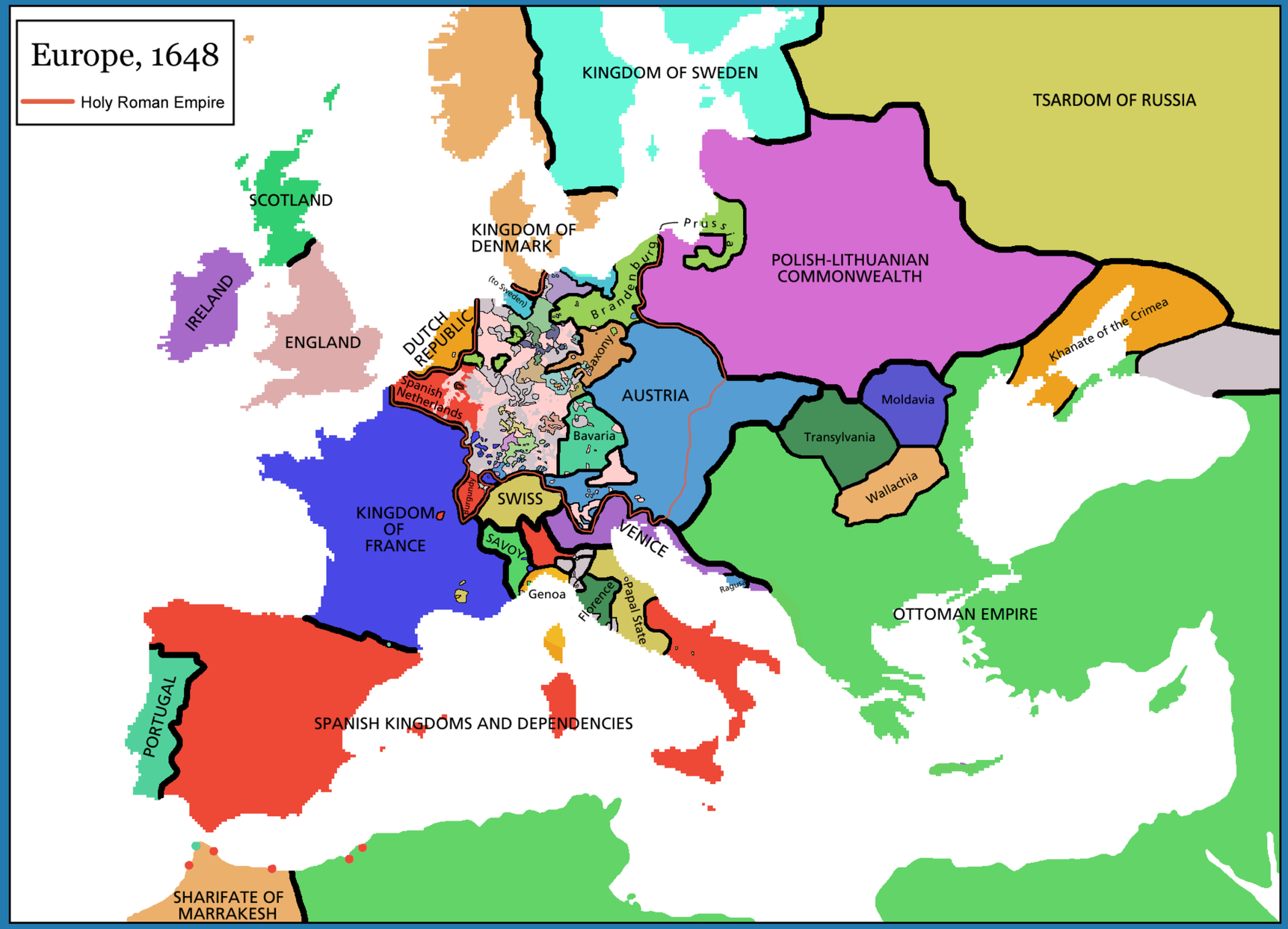
STATE MAKING

The “state-making” process in Europe culminated in the Treaty of Westphalia (1648), which marked the end of a conflict involving most European powers, the so-called “Thirty Years War.”

The Treaty is still of great significance because, for the first time, it recognized the “sovereignty” of Europe’s territorial rulers—by signing the Treaty, European rulers essentially agreed to respect one another’s autonomy and territorial integrity, even after defeats in war.

These innovations in technology, diplomacy, and statecraft lead to the emergence of some of the characteristics of the modern state—especially, an increasingly effective organization claiming a monopoly on the legitimate use of physical force.

Later, advances in mapping technology made it possible to draw precise boundaries, thereby completing the process.



Europe in 1648

STATE MAKING

What accounts for the success/failure of state-building processes? Tilly (1985) identified six conditions:

(1) Availability of extractable resources;
(2) A relatively protected position in time and space;
(3) A continuous supply of effective "political entrepreneurs;"
(4) Success in war;
(5) Homogeneity (or successful homogenization) of subject populations;
(6) Strong coalitions of the central power with the landed nobility.

Is that all? Hardly!

All this may explain the map of Europe in 1648. But, to understand how the current political map of the world was forged, we need to focus on processes of "nation-building" and "national integration," which began in Europe around this time.

NATION BUILDING

While processes of “state-making” or “state formation” tell the story of how state organizations successfully asserted their authority over a given territory, processes of “nation-building” were (initially) driven by the reaction to “royal absolutism.”

Originally, absolute monarchs drew their authority from “divine right,” but popular movements beginning in the seventeenth century increasingly rejected “natural” hierarchies of superior and inferior men and began to call for limitations in royal authority based on the notion that “the people” should be sovereign.

Almost everywhere, the content of these demands was inspired by the ideology of “nationalism.” This ideology inspired civil wars and revolutions in England (1640s), the United States (1776), and France (1789). Elsewhere, nationalist movements gradually succeeded in their quest to limit government power, forcing rulers to base their legitimacy on the sovereignty of “the nation.”

"NATIONALISM IS AN INFANTILE DISEASE.
IT IS THE MEASLES OF MANKIND."
-ALBERT EINSTEIN



NATION BUILDING

What is a nation? Benedict Anderson (1983) defines it as follows:

"A nation is an imagined political community,
and imagined as both inherently limited and sovereign."

Several elements of this definition require further explication:

Why "imagined"? Because individual members know only a tiny fraction of the other members, "yet in the minds of each lives the image of their communion." The point is that nations were invented, not discovered.

Why "limited"? Because every nation has finite, albeit elastic, boundaries, beyond which exist other nations.

Why "sovereign"? Each nation dreams to be "free," which means having a state; sovereignty belongs to the nation, not to its rulers.

Why "community"? Because the nation is conceived as a "comradeship" of equal citizens; the idea of fraternity makes it possible to kill and esp. to die for the nation.


LIBERTÉ
ÉGALITÉ
FRATERNITÉ

NATION BUILDING

In Europe, the transformation of all political units into so-called "nation-states" was completed by 1919 (end of World War I), thanks to:

(i) The breakup of old, multi-national empires (Austro-Hungarian, Ottoman, Russian) into smaller units along national (mostly ethno-linguistic) lines.

(ii) The unification of new "nations" from the aggregation of smaller, previously independent units (Germany, Italy).

Why did we end up with the nations we got?

In Europe, Anderson (1983) attributes that to "print capitalism:" i.e., the need for the print industry to use languages that people could understand (not Latin), but with sufficiently large coverage to ensure the existence of a viable market.



Cambridge University Press.
Stanford's Geog! Estab!, London.



Europe in 1919

NATION BUILDING

"National languages" would come to define the various nations' boundaries, while the spread of daily newspapers allowed people to "imagine" their nations by following events in other parts of the same countries.

State promotion and the competition for state jobs then played a decisive role in the spread of national languages.

Whether by conflict, revolution, or reform, nationalism changed the internal organization as well as the external boundaries of modern "nation-states," esp. through the promotion of ideas of "popular sovereignty" and "equal citizenship" (which, in turn, provided the basis for the rule of law and democracy).

The success of nationalist movements had a lot to do with the fact that "absolutist" rulers were often not as strong as they claimed to be, so they could be overthrown in some cases and forced into compromises in other cases.

NATION BUILDING

Eventually, the threatened elites of every major state adopted nationalist discourse and promoted their "official nationalism."

"Official nationalism" was the product of "an anticipatory strategy" adopted by dominant groups "threatened with marginalization or exclusion" in the new "nationally-imagined community"—the resulting ideologies typically de-emphasized individual equality, played up militarism, and promoted the state's image as the embodiment of the nation.

Either way, the spread of nationalism in the 1800s and 1900s eventually reshaped the external borders and internal organization of countries worldwide.

In fact, Anderson (1983) points out that the earliest "nation-states" were created, not in Europe, but in the so-called "New World" out of old colonial empires.

This was especially the case in North and South America.

NATION BUILDING

In North America, the “revolutionary war” waged by the United States against the British was inspired by nationalist ideas, such as those enshrined in the “Declaration of Independence” (1776).

In South America, nation-states emerged by roughly the 1820s after shaking off the rule of Spain and Portugal: these nations are defined not by language, but on the basis of old colonial administrative borders.

Anderson refers to these as “Creole nationalisms” (Creole is a word referring to the descendants of European settlers in the Americas).

This is a form of nationalism that “was pioneered by settler populations from the Old Country, who shared religion, language and customs with the metropole but increasingly felt oppressed by and alienated from it.”



Later, the justification for these nationalisms expanded to feature the supposedly "distinctive histories" of these nations, "and especially their demographic blending of settler and indigenous peoples, to say nothing of local traditions, geographies, climates, and so forth."

NATION BUILDING

In the rest of the world, nationalism spread by imitation. By the twentieth century, much of the world was colonized by European states.

European control over Africa and Asia expanded/deepened thanks to the Industrial Revolution in the 1800s, which created a massive asymmetry in the wealth/technology (esp. guns and battleships) available to Europeans compared to others.

The Industrial Revolution in Europe was facilitated by the creation of modern states, which promoted economic growth and allowed trade to flourish within and across national borders. What few independent countries remained in Asia developed top-down, "official nationalisms" (Japan, Siam/Thailand) copied from the West.

In China, a nationalist movement that mixed "the popular nationalism of the worldwide anti-imperialist movement with the official nationalism of the late nineteenth century" ended the Manchu dynasty in 1910s.

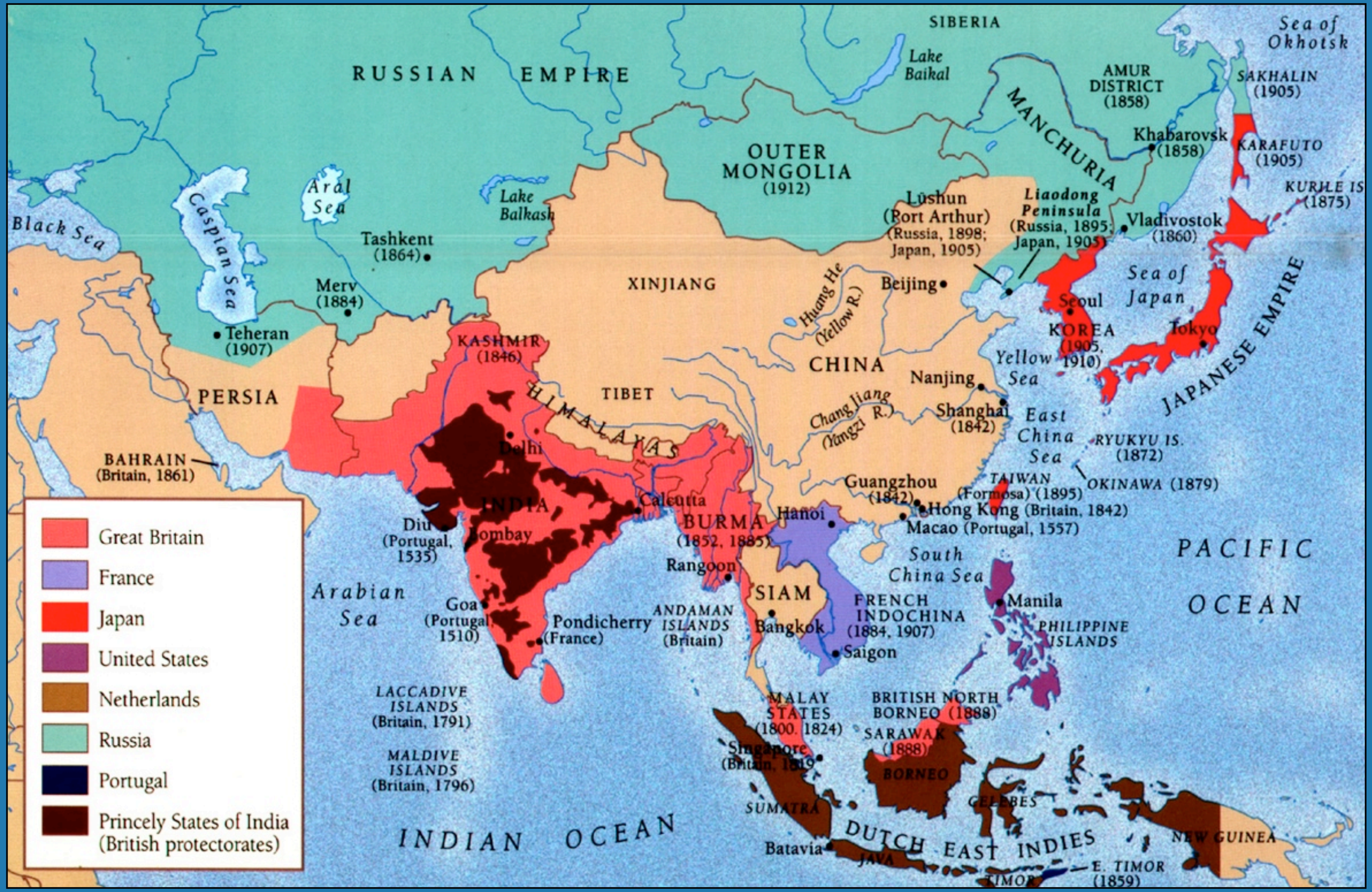
NATION BUILDING

In the colonies elsewhere in Asia, local intellectuals adopted European ideas about nationalism thanks in large part to the actions of Europeans themselves.

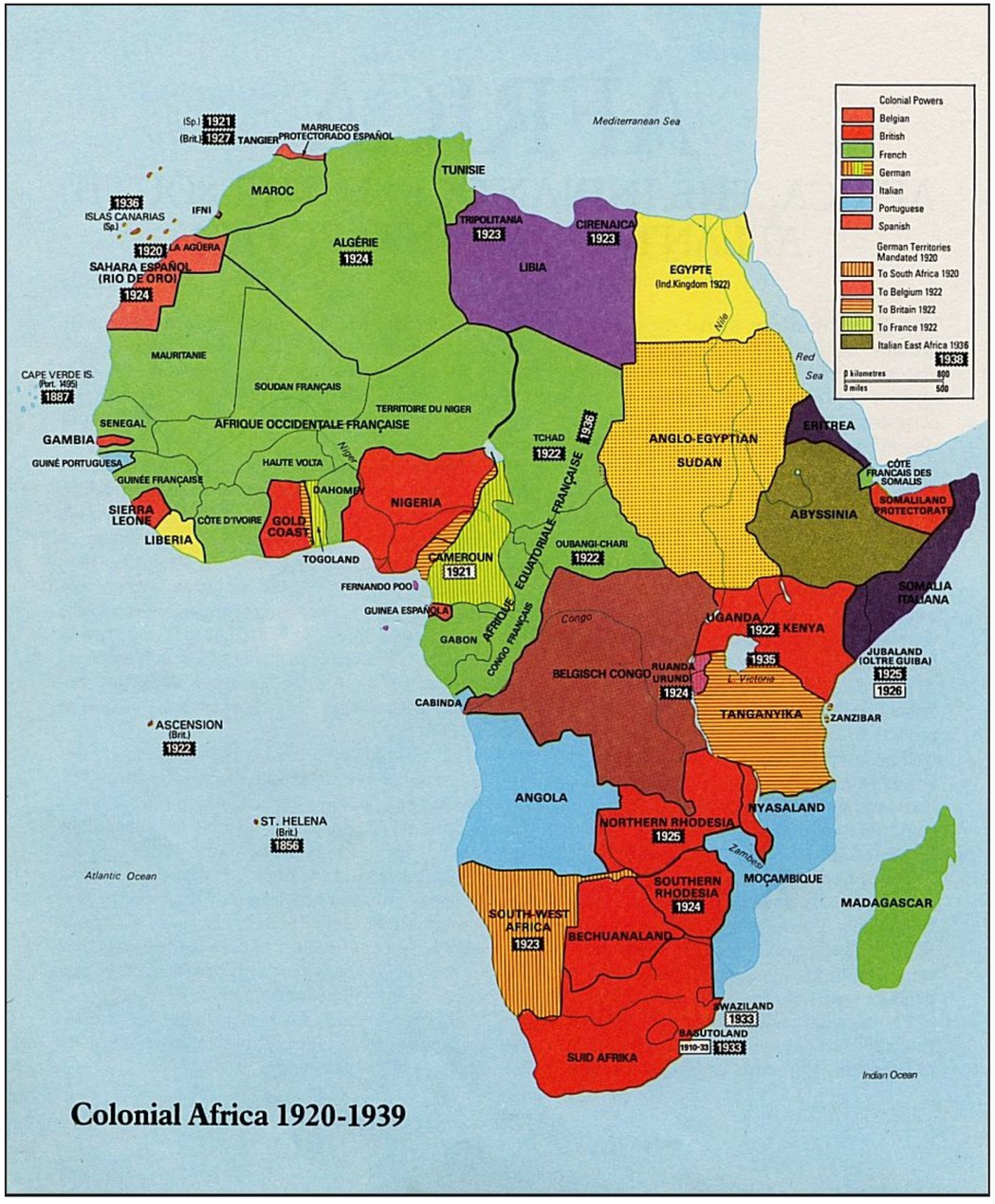
Some of them picked up these ideas while studying in Europe (e.g., the Philippines' José Rizal in Spain, Vietnam's Ho Chi Minh in France); others became enamored with these ideas while studying locally, in schools where Europeans trained colonial administrators.

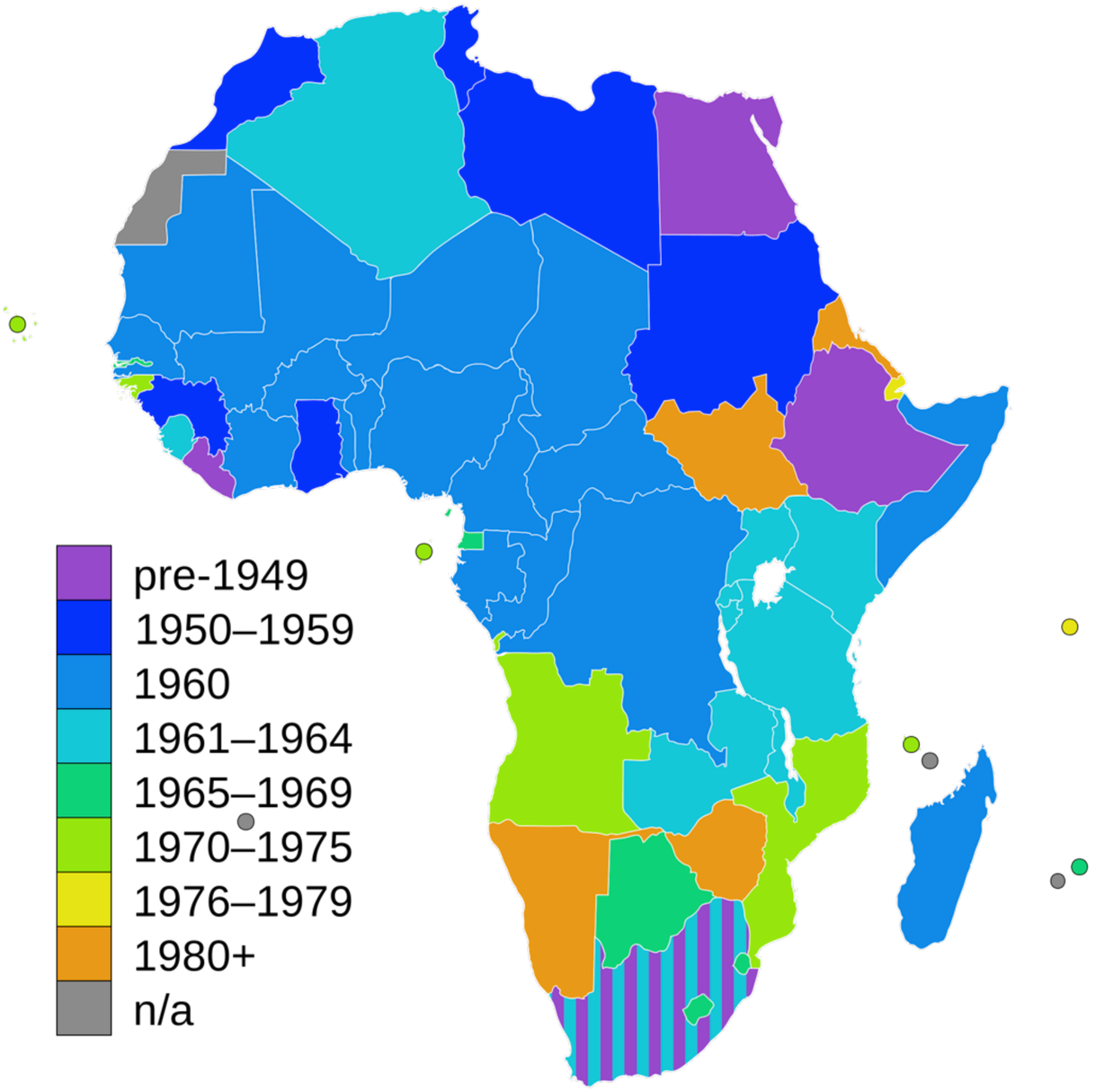
Schools/colonial offices brought young intellectuals from various parts of colonial dominions to study/work together, fostering camaraderie between them.

Obviously, local nationalisms subsequently became the basis of anti-colonial struggles; once the Europeans left (after WWII), a plethora of new nation-states were created whose external boundaries were very similar to colonial boundaries.


SIBERIA
Sea of Okhotsk
RUSSIAN EMPIRE
Lake Baikal
AMUR DISTRICT (1858)
SAKHALIN (1905)
MANCHURIA
Khabarovsk (1858)
KARAFUTO (1905)
KURILE IS (1875)
OUTER MONGOLIA (1912)
Aral Sea
Lake Balkash
Lüshun (Port Arthur) (Russia, 1898; Japan, 1905)
Liaodong Peninsula (Russia, 1895; Japan, 1905)
Vladivostok (1860)
Black Sea
Caspian Sea
Tashkent (1864)
XINJIANG
Huang He (Yellow R.)
Beijing
Sea of Japan
Merv (1884)
Seoul
KOREA (1905, 1910)
Tokyo
JAPANESE EMPIRE
Teheran (1907)
KASHMIR (1846)
CHINA
Yellow Sea
PERSIA
TIBET
HIMALAYAS
Nanjing
Chang Jiang (Yangzi R.)
Shanghai (1842)
East China Sea
RYUKYU IS. (1872)
Delhi
BAHRAIN (Britain, 1861)
TAIWAN (Formosa) (1895)
OKINAWA (1879)
Guangzhou (1842)
Hong Kong (Britain, 1842)
Calcutta
INDIA
Hanoi
Macao (Portugal, 1557)
Diu (Portugal, 1535)
Bombay
BURMA (1852, 1885)
South China Sea
PACIFIC OCEAN
Rangoon
Arabian Sea
Goa (Portugal, 1510)
SIAM
Manila
ANDAMAN ISLANDS (Britain)
FRENCH INDOCHINA (1884, 1907)
Pondicherry (France)
Bangkok
PHILIPPINE ISLANDS
Saigon
LACCADIVE ISLANDS (Britain, 1791)
MALAY STATES (1800, 1824)
BRITISH NORTH BORNEO (1888)
SARAWAK (1888)
Singapore (Britain, 1819)
MALDIVE ISLANDS (Britain, 1796)
BORNEO
SUMATRA
CELEBES
INDIAN OCEAN
DUTCH EAST INDIES
NEW GUINEA
Batavia
JAVA
E. TIMOR (1859)
TIMOR
Great Britain
France
Japan
United States
Netherlands
Russia
Portugal
Princely States of India (British protectorates)


MONGOLIA
CHINA
JAPAN
TURKEY
SYRIA
IRAQ
IRAN
PAKISTAN
SAUDI ARABIA
INDIA
BURMA
THAILAND
CAMBODIA
PHILIPPINES
MOROCCO
ALGERIA
LIBYA
EGYPT
MAURITANIA
MALI
NIGER
CHAD
SUDAN
NIGERIA
ETHIOPIA
SOMALIA
YEMEN
MALDIVES
SRI LANKA
CENTRAL AFRICAN REPUBLIC
DEMOCRATIC REPUBLIC OF THE CONGO
UGANDA
KENYA
TANZANIA
SEYCHELLES
ANGOLA
ZAMBIA
MOZAMBIQUE
ZIMBABWE
NAMIBIA
BOTSWANA
SOUTH AFRICA
LESOTHO
MADAGASCAR
INDONESIA
PAPUA NEW GUINEA
AUSTRALIA
FEDERATED STATES OF MICRONESIA
FIJI
SOUTH ATLANTIC OCEAN
INDIAN OCEAN
Arabian Sea
Bay of Bengal
South China Sea
Philippine Sea
Mediterranean Sea
Black Sea
Equator
Tropic of Capricorn (23°27')
St. Helena (U.K.)


Colonial Powers
Belgian
British
French
German
Italian
Portuguese
Spanish
German Territories Mandated 1920
To South Africa 1920
To Belgium 1922
To Britain 1922
To France 1922
Italian East Africa 1936
1938
Mediterranean Sea
Red Sea
Atlantic Ocean
Indian Ocean
Congo
Nile
Niger
Zambezi
L. Victoria
MAROC
TUNISIE
ALGÉRIE
1924
LIBIA
TRIPOLITANIA
1923
CIRENAICA
1923
EGYPTE
(Ind.Kingdom 1922)
MAURITANIE
SOUDAN FRANÇAIS
TERRITOIRE DU NIGER
AFRIQUE OCCIDENTALE FRANÇAISE
SENEGAL
GAMBIA
GUINÉ PORTUGUESA
GUINÉE FRANÇAISE
HAUTE VOLTA
DAHOMEY
NIGERIA
SIERRA LEONE
LIBERIA
CÔTE D'IVOIRE
GOLD COAST
TOGOLAND
CAMEROUN
1921
TCHAD
1922
1936
AFRIQUE EQUATORIALE FRANÇAISE
OUBANGI-CHARI
1922
GABON
CONGO FRANÇAIS
FERNANDO POO
GUINEA ESPAÑOLA
CABINDA
BELGISCH CONGO
RUANDA URUNDI
1924
ANGLO-EGYPTIAN SUDAN
ERITREA
ABYSSINIA
CÔTE FRANÇAIS DES SOMALIS
SOMALILAND PROTECTORATE
SOMALIA ITALIANA
UGANDA
1922
KENYA
1935
JUBALAND (OLTRE GUIBA)
1925
1926
TANGANYIKA
ZANZIBAR
ANGOLA
NORTHERN RHODESIA
1925
NYASALAND
MOÇAMBIQUE
SOUTHERN RHODESIA
1924
SOUTH-WEST AFRICA
1923
BECHUANALAND
SWAZILAND
1933
BASUTOLAND
1910-33
1933
SUID AFRIKA
MADAGASCAR
ASCENSION
(Brit.)
1922
ST. HELENA
(Brit.)
1856
ISLAS CANARIAS
(Sp.)
1936
IFNI
1969
LA AGÜERA
1920
SAHARA ESPAÑOL
(RIO DE ORO)
1924
CAPE VERDE IS.
(Port. 1495)
1887
(Sp.) 1921
(Brit.) 1927
TANGIER
MARRUECOS
PROTECTORADO ESPAÑOL
kilometres 800
miles 500
Colonial Africa 1920-1939


pre-1949
1950–1959
1960
1961–1964
1965–1969
1970–1975
1976–1979
1980+
n/a

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